

THE ORDER OF THE GILT FRAME

Candidate,

In the records of the Order of the Gilt Frame, your name was inscribed long before this letter was sealed. This was not done lightly, nor recently. You were observed for some time before the Council reached its determination.

Seldom does the Council reach such swift consensus on a candidate. What drew our attention was not any single quality, but a pattern: you linger where others pass by. You notice what the frame contains, not merely what hangs within it. This is rarer than you know.

Every generation, the Order identifies those who possess this gift. We call it the Sight. It is not knowledge, nor talent, nor any faculty the world has a ready name for. It is the willingness to look until the looking changes you.

Enclosed within these words is everything you need to begin. Read more carefully than you have ever read. The answer to the first threshold is already in your hands.

Consider this your formal summons. The trials ahead will ask nothing of strength or speed, only of sight. You will be sent to places where the Order has walked, asked to see what others have overlooked, and recognized for what you find.

Look not for what is obvious. The Order has never valued the obvious. What we have left behind does not announce itself. It waits in plain sight for those with the patience to see it. You will learn, in time, to read what others walk past.

Each threshold you cross will reveal another. The first awaits you now. Others have crossed these same thresholds before you, and the path they marked is the path you will follow.

Accept what you find, and the Order will know you have answered. A sign will follow this letter. When it arrives, you will understand that the summons is real.

Refuse, and this letter is merely paper. But you will not refuse. The Council has watched you long enough to know.

Long have the frames watched. Long have they waited. What they guard has survived fire, neglect, and those who would see it destroyed. The Order endures. So will what it protects.

You have been chosen, Sparrow. The Order does not explain how it finds its candidates, only that it does. You are one of us now, whether you know it yet or not.

— The Registrar

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